

3. This is Not a Pipe

Recently, AAA recovered a lot of Old World art from an abandoned art school in the Hollow. They're going to be displayed to the public alongside a new solo-artist exhibition called "The Common Life". It features paintings that depict what life was like in the Old World through Old World painting techniques. It's time to put on your fanciest clothes, grab the exhibit's free foods and drinks, and appreciate good art with good company.

Series: The Golden State (3/?)

Type: Investigation, Roleplay, No Combat

Mood: Whodunnit

Notes

- Time: 20:00-00:00, start with 15 minutes grace
- CW: Mild racist implications
- Priority for @Archivists-of-the-Academic-Annals
- Catered to @Actor, @Instigator, @Storyteller
- **Very investigation heavy:** you'll need to be **active** in exploring places, talking to NPCs, and piecing clues together by yourself
- Despite the topic, the overall tone will NOT be too dark/heavy, but it'll still treat the topic seriously. Please respect this tone!
 - (If your character is the serious type or the type who's aware of the session's topics, roleplay as much as you want)
- React with :art: if interested!

Session opening

Ready question: What do you think of the exhibition "The Common Life"? If you're not in the AAA, what brings you to this art exhibition?

- **Reminder:** Upon entering the AAA's headquarters, all your pertatech possessions (except Cyborg prosthetics) are to be left at the front desk security. This is to keep visitors and staff safe, as well as to prevent further damaging and/or irradiating relics.
For this session, your powers and rituals are not accessible.
- Please put your passive PERCEPTION and INSIGHT (10+mod) in your server name.

15-minute ORP Setup

The Players are going from the AAA's lobby to the Exhibition Hall. On the way, they pass by the backrooms where exhibition pieces are temporarily stored. They see and hear:

- A muffled, but very heated argument from an office between a male and female voice. They hear the woman say *"I'm not having this argument again. This is final, and that's it!"* Soon, JONAH storms out the office. He doesn't notice the Players.
- At the same time, SLOANE opens the door for CAROLINE to leave the Backroom. The Players recognise her as the exhibition's artist from posters.
- Right after, JONAH goes into the Backroom. The Players enter the Hall filled with food, drinks, art, and other guests.
- A short while after, FANGHE runs in, out of breath. She only acknowledges the Players with a glance before disappearing into the crowd.

Session Start

Caroline and Sloane appear in the hall, followed by AAA staff carrying Caroline's paintings. Caroline watches as the staff mounts her pieces onto gallery walls. All of her paintings are veiled: they'll be revealed when Chaarani officially opens her exhibition.

The Crime

Charani Elliot, the director of the AAA, officially opens the exhibition by pressing a button that'll unveil all the artwork. That reveals that all the pieces are vandalised! The pieces featured Old World humans doing everyday things in the Old World. Now, parts of the pieces have been ripped to show Cyborg prosthetics.

Still trying to appease to her guests, Chaarani plays off the vandalism as surprise additions to the exhibition. She **asks everyone to remain in the exhibition** until the surprise is resolved, and encourages everyone to continue looking at all the artworks while enjoying food and drink.

Meanwhile, she pulls the Players aside to investigate the two crime scenes. They can investigate either the Paintings or the Backroom. Caroline supervises her Paintings. Chaarani supervises the Backroom, where the painting was stored before being displayed here.

Before We Begin: Meta Notes

Game management

Each NPC has an Alibi, a Motive, and a Secret. Evidence supporting each of these can be found in the crime scenes or by talking to other NPCs. At any point, the Players can **unanimously accuse** an NPC of being the culprit. Each player needs to give a reason of why they think the NPC is guilty.

This accusation is final. The real culprit will be revealed afterwards. The Players win if they're correct and lose if they're wrong.

Thread management

This 'Exhibition Hall' thread will be used for Players to reconvene and discuss in character. Make 2 new threads for the 2 crime scenes below, tell players to divide themselves into groups of 4, and then to choose where they want to go.

After the Players have searched the crime scenes, make 2 new threads to question NPCs.

Comments on notes

Players can persuade NPCs to reveal their secrets or expose their lies using evidence or skill checks. No specific skill checks or DCs are written for this. NPCs may react differently depending on the method used.

The Paintings

are beautifully and skilfully painted using the techniques of Old World masters. Even the vandalised Cyborg parts are also skilfully painted, though done in a different style and medium. Caroline, trying not to freak out, accompanies the Players.

What Caroline Knows

- Last month, the AAA opened up submissions for today's art exhibition to showcase New Victorville's talents. Caroline submitted some older paintings and was accepted.
- "Director Elliot" (what Caroline calls Chaarani) liked how she paired Old World painting techniques with depicting Old World life.
 - If asked, Caroline developed her painting style by studying from the AAA's archives and by venturing into the Hollow herself.
- Caroline thinks she was accepted because people today are nostalgic for the world before the Hollow, and that her paintings make it easy to romanticise life back then.
- The paintings were moved into here in the morning directly from Caroline's studio. Chaarani and Caroline were there to supervise the move.
- They both checked the paintings: everything was normal and fine.
- They were brought here, to the backroom, and were veiled.
- The paintings were left here for a few hours until they were moved to the exhibition to be displayed.
 - If asked why they didn't display the paintings before the exhibit opened, Caroline simply says it's because she was nervous. That's why her paintings were veiled, too. This is her first solo exhibition, after all.

Inspecting the Paintings

Each painting's canvas is made of a layer of fabric stretched and pinned to a wooden frame. Clearly, there are 2 fabric layers: the original layer, and the Cyborg layer. If the Players offer alternate skills to do the same thing in a way that makes sense, let them do it. If it makes sense to, change the DC to match the alternate skill to the task.

- HEAL DC 11: The tears were made by something long and sharp.
 - HEAL DC 15: The tears are also very hasty and messy. It's like someone tore them in a rush or out of anger.
- PERCEPTION DC 11: The player notices that while the original layer is pinned to the outside of the frame (like normal), the Cyborg layer is pinned to the inside of the frame.
 - NATURE DC 15 or PERCEPTION DC 23: The Cyborg layer looks newly pinned to the frame.
- THIEVERY/DEXTERITY DC 18: The players can separate the Cyborg layer from the canvas frame without damaging the Cyborg layer.
 - FAIL: They damage the Cyborg layer.
 - NAT 1: They also damage the original layer.
 - There are no mechanical penalties for damaging either layer. Caroline just freaks out. If the original layer is damaged, Caroline freaks out even more at seeing her hard work being destroyed, and Chaarani won't be happy!

After separating the Cyborg layer, this is what the Players can see.

- PERCEPTION DC 15: The Cyborg layer looks newer than the original layer.
 - NATURE/HEAL DC 15 or PERCEPTION DC 23: It looks *much* newer. Judging from how white the canvas is and how vibrant the paint is, it looks like it was painted this month.
- The art styles are different. The original layer looks like the Baroque and Classical styles of Old World masters. The Cyborg layer looks more Impressionistic, with looser brush strokes and less 'realistic' colours.
 - HEAL DC 13 or PERCEPTION DC 23: Though both layers use oil paint, another type of paint is also used on the Cyborg layer. Its base is painted with spray paint.
- The Cyborg layer is signed with "DEVIANT".
 - STREETWISE DC 12: DEVIANT is a rogue, anonymous, artist. Though a bit niche, they're popular in the street art community. DEVIANT's famous for creating graffiti and murals overnight, or for leaving paintings out in public, whether legal or not. All their works are very politically charged: they appreciate Radiators and showcases their struggles, especially for Cyborgs.
 - STREETWISE DC 15: After thorough but fast searching, the Player can confirm that DEVIANT has no online presence, so they can't be traced. Pictures of DEVIANT's works are posted by random people who see them.

The Backroom

is a cool room that has direct access to the exhibition hall. Some pieces of art are still stored here. Chaarani takes the Players to where the artwork was stored, which is in sight of a SECURITY CAMERA.

Charani can access the Backroom's security footage from her tablet for the Players. She won't access the office's security footage. She'll also ask the Players to call her Director Elliot.

What Chaarani Knows

- Last month, the AAA opened up submissions for today's art exhibition to showcase New Victorville's talents. There were a lot of submissions. Caroline was who Chaarani chose.
- The paintings were moved into here in the morning directly from Caroline's studio. Chaarani and Caroline were there to supervise the move.
- They both checked the paintings: everything was normal and fine.
- They were brought here, to the backroom, and were veiled.
- The paintings were left here for a few hours until they were moved to the exhibition to be displayed.
 - If asked why they didn't display the paintings before the exhibit opened, Chaarani says it was the artist's wishes. She wanted to be a bit performative and build excitement for her debut exhibition. That's why her paintings were veiled, too.
- Only AAA archivists are allowed in here. Their employee card is a key to enter the Backroom.
- If asked how she feels, Chaarani says she's very shocked and disappointed that she, the director of the AAA, could let this happen.
- PERCEPTION DC 15: The Player recognises her voice. She's the one who argued with Jonah.
- She deflects all other questions and tells the Players to focus on investigating. She wants this wrapped up neatly and quickly.

Reviewing the Security Camera Footage

The only possible suspects are those who looked at the paintings in the Backroom before they were taken out to the Hall, which is when the players arrived.

There were five people who came in to look at the paintings. Each time they did, they lifted the veil. Because the camera is behind the paintings, **the veil obscures anything the person does while looking at the painting.**

This is the **timeline**:

- CAROLINE came in multiple times to look at her paintings for varying periods of time.

- CHAARANI came in twice: with CAROLINE, and later on by herself.
- Then, SLOANE came in an hour before the exhibition opened. She stayed here and often looked at the paintings, while also looking at other artwork and reading a book. She was the one who let people in and out of the Backroom.
- A few minutes before the Players arrived, SLOANE left.
- This is when FANGHE entered the Backroom. She looked around all the art here, including the paintings.
- Suddenly, she looked shocked. SLOANE has re-entered the Backroom to wait there.
- As SLOANE walked around the Backroom, FANGHE quickly escaped without being noticed.
- CAROLINE enters the Backroom for the last time.
- At the time the Players arrive, CAROLINE leaves and JONAH storms in. He aggressively lifts the veil to look at the paintings before leaving in a rush.
- SLOANE holds the door open for staff to move the paintings to the hall. CAROLINE is there to watch.
- Throughout this footage, all these people also carried bags.

This means the only suspects are CAROLINE, CHAARANI, FANGHE, JONAH, and SLOANE. When the Players congregate, they can start questioning each suspect. If they decide not to question one of the suspects for whatever reason, their loss lmao

Before We Continue: The Truth

The artist, **Caroline Gladkov**, is the culprit. Though she looks like a Non-Radiator, she's actually legally a Cyborg: her heart is purely mechanical due to an accident she had in the Hollow. It's attached to a battery that's stuck on her torso.

In her professional art career, she passes as a Non-Radiator for obvious benefits. However, she also creates politically-charged art under the pseudonym 'DEVIANT'. Last month, DEVIANT felt brave enough to stand up for Radiators. She submitted her collection of paintings to the AAA's submission call for an upcoming exhibition. Her collection featured Old World Cyborgs doing everyday Old World activities: a statement that Cyborgs have always existed, and that they're humans with feelings and thoughts like everyone else.

It was quickly rejected. Angry, Caroline submitted older paintings she made that would appeal to the masses: Old World Commons. When she was accepted, she decided to add the new, second Cyborg layer beneath the original painting.

The Cyborgs were painted in the same pose and setting as their original versions. This was so that when the AAA accepted Caroline's collection, she can rip the top layer in the Backroom, and reveal to everyone the Cyborgs that have always existed. This is the real reason why she asked the paintings to be veiled and for them to be displayed right before her exhibition began.

However, despite how bold and brave DEVIANT is, Caroline is a very shy and nervous person. The reason she visited the Backrooms multiple times was because she was having second thoughts about tearing her paintings. She did it last-minute in her last visit to the Backroom, which is when the Players arrived. This is why the tears were very hasty.

The way she tore her painting was using a big pair of scissors. Despite being a weapon, she was allowed to bring this with her as it is a part of her medical equipment. She has a doctor's note saying that she has a 'pacemaker': if it failed and her heart suddenly stopped, her clothes need to be opened fast for a defibrillator, and the fastest way to do that is with scissors.

Chaarani Elliot

Female, 'Common' (has Chimera genome), 55 y/o

Personality and Characteristics

A smooth-talking businesswoman at heart. Though she was once a regular Archivist, after years of hard work, she's now Director Elliot and expects to be called and treated as such. She's very cool-headed and professional.

Maintaining a good image for herself and the AAA is her priority. That's why she doesn't mind being questioned, and that's why she has made certain decisions others dislike...

If the Players become too interrogative or pushy, she firmly reminds them that, even if there are police officers in the party, this is not an official police investigation. They hold no real jurisdiction or power, and they are still under her payroll.

Suspect Profile

Alibi(s):

- She's AAA's director. She cares a lot about this Faction. Why would she taint their reputation and also her own reputation?

Motive(s):

- Her long, pointed nail file could've been used to tear through the canvas.
- Her being vague and not answering things clearly alone is suspicious.

Secret(s):

- Chaarani lives life and identifies as a Common. That's what she's legally listed as. But technically, Chaarani is a Chimera.

- She and her late Chimera husband passed their Chimera genome down to Fanghe, where it manifested much more strongly. That's how they both of them found out they are Chimeras.
- This isn't really a secret because Fanghe exists. However, she also doesn't say this to anyone.
- What she does keep a secret is how she raised Fanghe as a Common. (See below)
- She upholds the truth of how Fanghe was kicked out of the AAA due to misbehaviour. This is a lie: Fanghe left by herself. (See below)

What's in her bag:

- Lipstick
- **A nail file**, just in case she need a touch-up.
- Her locked tablet
- Her AAA card
- Other normal, unnotable things

Chaarani's knowledge and opinions on...

Jonah

- "Mr. Vandermeer is one of the best Archivists we have. He's at the forefront of our expeditions. I knew he had talent when he first joined the AAA. I'm proud to have witnessed it flourish."
- If asked about her **fight** with Jonah, she brushes it off.
 - "He's a young man from a different generation, a different time. We're bound to have our differences in how we view the world."

Fanghe

- "That girl is something else. Yes, she's my daughter, but she's still something else. I'm sorry for whatever trouble she caused you."
- Chaarani doesn't approve of Fanghe's reckless behaviour. She's disappointed in her.
- "I wouldn't put it past that girl to be the culprit. For her sake, she'd better not be the culprit."
- If asked about Fanghe being raised as a Common, she says, "In this world, why wouldn't I?"
 - She doesn't say anything else: it's not relevant to the case.
- If her lie about Fanghe being kicked out is revealed, she refuses to elaborate. If she keeps being pushed, she'll get mad.

Sloane

- "Ms. Croix is... unique. To be honest, I know more about her work than I know about her, but her research is in the field of the sciences, which I'm not familiar with. I'm more of a linguist."
- "I only know that her research was significant enough for her face to be on display. I do not know her personally. You may have better luck with Mr. Vandermeer."
- If asked about Sloane being mistreated by the AAA: "Unfortunately, that decision was the previous director's, not mine."
 - If pushed more: "I'm aware of her talents being put to better use elsewhere. However, my priorities are focused on the AAA's progression as a whole -- not on one singular person."

Caroline

- Her knowledge is the same as the above section in The Backroom.
- "She seems to be the nervous, anxious type. That, or she's very nervous about this being her first solo exhibition. I feel terrible that this is how it had to go."

Djoena "Jonah" Vandermeer

Male, 'Common' (Chimera), 27 y/o

Personality and Characteristics

Charismatic and chivalrous, yet stoic and rugged: he's the embodiment of being a classy gentleman. Think James Bond, but friendlier. (Or even *gasp* Indiana Jones??) He's easy to talk to, but once he's provoked about his motives and secrets, he becomes cold and puts up a wall.

He's *very* adamant in being innocent. If Players keep accusing or provoking him, he becomes very snappy and defensive -- especially since he's already in a bad mood!

Suspect Profile

Alibi(s):

- He's very passionate and dedicated about collecting and preserving relics -- he's been doing it ever since starting his Masters thesis. So why would he do such a thing to a piece of art??
- He's been in the AAA for years. He's loyal to their true cause: he wouldn't betray them like this.

Motive(s):

- He just had a heated argument, and he seemed very angry when he went into the Backroom. He may have torn the painting in rage.
- He has a quill with a sharp and long nib. With his strength, it can tear through the canvas.
- Secret revealed: He's trying to get back at Chaarani by making her/the AAA look bad.

Secret(s):

- Everyone thinks he's a Common, and he makes sure of it. He's actually a Chimera!
 - If the Players expose this with what Fanghe said: he admits it with a sigh, and tells them not to tell others.
 - He has no visible Chimera attributes, as everything is internal: red-green colour blindness, superior sense of smell, great athletic prowess and endurance, very loyal. Basically, he has dog DNA fused into him.
 - He'll tell the story about how his family is one of many who, during the Hollow, fused with their animal companions: "Because 'man's best friend' couldn't leave man alone."
- He just had a big fight with Chaarani. (See below)
- Though he hides it, he had always held a grudge against Chaarani. (See below)

What's in his bag:

- A sleek quill with a **long metal nib**
- A bottle of ink
- A journal for daily tasks: he likes "doing things the old-fashioned way"
- His AAA card
- Other normal, unnotable things

Jonah's knowledge and opinions on...

Charani

- She's been around ever since he joined the AAA after getting his Masters degree. They've worked together a lot.
- She's a strong, capable leader. She's very aware about the state of today's world. He likes how she's pushing to recruit Radiators and to explore the Hollow more.
 - INSIGHT DC 20: Though he's not lying, there's something he's keeping behind his cool smile... and it's something that's been boiling in him for a while.
- If asked about his **fight**: he smiles and says it's not important. He just got caught in the heat of the moment. He doesn't reveal who it was with.
 - INSIGHT DC 11: He's lying. It's still bothering him.
- If persuaded to talk about his **fight**, he reveals it was with Chaarani.

- Last month, she rejected an artist called "DEVIANT" for the exhibition. A lot of AAA members agreed that it'll be good for humanising Radiators and putting them in a good light publicly.
- Chaarani rejected it because she didn't want the AAA to be associated with supporting 'roughish, deviant behaviour'. But because of her previous actions, Jonah suspects it's because she doesn't want to spotlight Cyborgs.
- "She doesn't want the AAA to take risks and be controversial. She wants the AAA to be safe and palatable. She has always been that kind of person."
- What really pissed him off was when Chaarani said she was going to feature artwork from the last expedition to CalArts. He was excited for the Cyborg and Chimera art to be displayed. Today, he found out none of them were.
- They've had these kinds of discussions before, even before Chaarani became the director. CalArts was the final straw.
- "Charani's better than the last director, but they're still similar in some ways..."

Fanghe

- "A good kid, but she's troubled. She and her mom have a rocky relationship. I can't blame her, but it's not my place to talk about it."
- He can't be persuaded to talk about it. But if pushed, and if he has already talked about his fight with Chaarani, he says: "Well, Chaarani's like *that*. She calls herself a Common. Her daughter's more obviously a Chimera. What do you think is going to happen between the two of them?"
- If asked if Fanghe was kicked out of the AAA or left, he says "That's not my business."
 - He can be persuaded to give a proper answer: "She left."
 - He doesn't elaborate on why: again, not his business.

Sloane

- "Sloane's a good one. I know she's bitter and grumpy all the time, but she wasn't always like that. She's also dependable. She's *really* passionate about her work -- sometimes too passionate -- and she's good at it. That's why she's been in the AAA for years... despite how the AAA's been treating her."
- If asked to elaborate, he will:
 - "I used to go on Hollow expeditions with Sloane all the time, until one day, she got really badly injured. To quote the Old World, she was Icarus, and 'she flew too close to the sun'."
 - "She can't go to the Hollow anymore. She's too fragile, and so are her cybernetics. When the doctors told her that, it broke her heart. Her entire life's worth of research was about researching the Old World's ecosystems to improve New Victorville's dome. It was the one love she had in life. Now, she can't do that anymore."
 - "She used to be one of the gold, shining stars of the AAA, y'know? The person you'd put on flyers and brochures. And now, they've tucked her away in a tiny office

no one sees and made her a pencil pusher. And a 'babysitter', in her own words."

- "They haven't even updated her picture on that wall of AAA's notable archivists, y'know? All because she looks 'disturbing' and 'unflattering'. All because an accident turned her into a Cyborg."
- "I've been trying to get Chaarani to get Sloane on some real work, but... that has yet to happen."

Caroline

- "She studied Old World paintings really well, that I can tell you. Her technique is impeccable. Otherwise, I can't say much about her. I've only just met her today, but I can see why the AAA chose her for the exhibition."
-

Chaarani-Bai Fanghe

Female, Chimera, 23 y/o

Personality and Characteristics

If punk rock was a person, it'll be Fanghe. She's rebellious, rough around the edges, and very angry at the world -- but she's justice-oriented, passionate, and open-minded. She has a big heart that's been hurt by people close to her. So, she protects it with rage-fuelled vigilantism.

She's very spiteful and vengeful, so she speaks very freely and openly about anything and everything. She wears her heart on her sleeve because she has nothing to hide!

Suspect Profile

Alibi(s):

- She was in the AAA, which means she does value the arts. She would never destroy art like that.
 - "The AAA may call me a monster, but I'm not a villain!"
- It's true that she originally was going to steal something from the AAA's backroom while everyone was distracted with the exhibition, but she thought the paintings were already displayed. She didn't know people were going to go into the Backroom to get them out so late.
 - "I didn't actually do *any* crime. Go check my bag. There's *nothing*."

Motive(s):

- She has been actively interfering with AAA's expeditions for a long time. This is her way of sending a message, which fits the Cyborg vandalism.
- She left the AAA, but the AAA twisted that narrative into kicking her out due to misbehaviour.
- She dislikes what she thinks the AAA does.
- She dislikes her mom, Chaarani, who's AAA's director. She also knows how image-conscious Chaarani is and can exploit that.
- As a Chimera, she has **retractable talons** that can tear through the canvas.

Secret(s):

- She knows Jonah's secret because he told her: he's a Chimera! (See below)
- She stole Sloane's AAA card to get inside the Backroom. (See below)

What's in her bag:

- Nothing. Literally nothing. It's an empty, deflated bag.

Fanghe's knowledge and opinions on...

Jonah

- "Jonah's cool. He's a nice guy. I like him. He's probably the only guy I like in the AAA. He's kind of stupid sometimes, but... no one's perfect."
- "We joined the AAA around the same time. I was fresh out of high school, and he finished his Masters. I learned a lot from him."
 - INSIGHT DC 11: Clearly, Fanghe looks up to him like a mentor figure.
 - INSIGHT DC 15: Not only does she sound guilty for disappointing him with what she has done -- she also knows something about him she's not telling the Players.
- DIPLOMACY DC 15: Players can persuade her to talk about Jonah. INTIMIDATION won't work: she's too rebellious!
 - "I'm a Chimera. I got the hair, the eyes, the talons, the feathers -- but if you passed by me on the street, you'd probably think I was a Common. Well, it's the same with Jonah. It's just even less obvious with him. He's got none of all *this*..."
 - "Anyway, he told that to me because he was trying to make me feel better or whatever. And I'm telling you this to knock some sense into his head! Some people here talk all sorts of shit about Chimera without knowing he's one. He's better off away from the AAA."
 - "But uh, don't tell anyone else about that, please... especially my mom. I actually want good things to happen to him, so don't tell anyone. At all. Not even Jonah. Okay? Or I'll fuck you up."
- If the Players keep calling him 'Djoena':
 - "Hey, you can call him Jonah, by the way. Or Jo. Djoena's a girl's name. Don't you know?"

- "Ha! Yeah, thought so. No one knows. That's why he hasn't changed his name. He can't be bothered. He thinks it's funny."

Chaarani

- Fanghe's mother. Their relationship is estranged.
- She really doesn't like her.
- "All you have to know is that I left the AAA because of her, and then she kept up the fucking rumour that they kicked me out! That was even before I found out she was the director. I have no idea when *that* happened."
- "But seriously, it's all just family drama bullshit. It's not relevant to this case, trust me."
- If the Players keep pushing, she'll spill because she wants to vent:
 - "A *very* long story short: my dad was a Radiator for the AAA. One day last year, he went into the Hollow and never came back. Search parties found nothing, so he's dead now. That's fine. What's *not* fine is that when the last director was reading out a speech for my dead dad, he fucking called him a *common*."
 - "You know what's worse? My mom did *nothing* about it. She never even corrected the story with her *own family*.*"
 - "She basically put a big, fucking middle finger in my face. So fuck her, and fuck the AAA. There's no one but a bunch of hypocrites here. 'Archiving history' my ass."

Sloane

- "...I feel bad for her. I don't know why she's still in the AAA. Maybe so she won't have to live off UBI."
- "I don't know a lot about her. We don't talk. Jonah told me the two of them used to go on Hollow expedition a lot, but then an accident happened and Sloane can't go out anymore. So she's a Cyborg now, and the AAA keeps her shelved away! No one's surprised!!"
- If asked about Sloane's AAA card, she looks guilty.
 - "Look, I didn't know she was going to posted there, okay? Her card was right there, so I swiped it... but I gave it back!"

Caroline

- "...I don't know. I never talked to her. Her art's good, I guess. It's actually really good -- too good for me to call her a sell-out or unoriginal."

Sloane Mallory Croix

Female, Cyborg, 33 y/o

Personality and Characteristics

She used to have light shining in those cold, dead eyes of hers, really. But that's been stripped away, so now, she just goes through life's motions not caring about what other people think of her. It's not like anyone's going to see her -- and it's not like she wants to see anyone, too!

She's aloof, blunt, and would rather not be here right now. But this exhibition has free booze, and one of the good things about having a feeding bag forever attached to your stomach is that alcohol can go directly into your system. "I'm not supposed to do this, but... a girl's gotta have her indulgences."

She'd proudly show it to the Players. She's drunk, and very sarcastic. She still hates being here, but she finds the entire case very funny and is here for the ride.

Suspect Profile

Alibi(s):

- She still is a member of the AAA, and she still doesn't want to get fired. How else can she get idol merch?

Motive(s):

- The vandalism is pro-Cyborg; she is a Cyborg.
- She was in the Backroom for the longest.
- Her **art style in her journal** is similar to the Cyborg vandalism.
- She let Fanghe steal her AAA card.
- The AAA has treated her like crap.

Secret(s):

- None. Not only is she drunk: she also doesn't care about anything.

What's in her bag:

- A very old, very thick, and very comprehensive field journal about her Hollow research. She makes scientific drawings in them. They're gorgeous and professional. Some drawings are more artistic with **impressionistic** still-life drawings of the Hollow.
- Old World textbooks about botany she borrowed from the library
- Her feeding bag that's attached to her stomach
- Some medical supplies
- Her AAA card
- Other normal, unnotable things

Sloane's knowledge and opinions on...

Jonah

- "Jonah? Huh. I remember his first day here. Before I babysat you AAA Radiators, I babysat him. Useless goddamn ray of sunshine."
- "Okay, he's not *that* useless. He's good at what he does. It's nice having some eye candy around here, too."
- "If you really want to know about him, go talk to him."
- If asked about her expeditions to the Hollow and/or her accident, she'll answer truthfully as per the information above.
- If asked about any romantic feelings towards Jonah: "*God* no. I'd rather just look. He's nice, but... *nahhh*."

Fanghe

- "Chaarani's daughter? Poor thing. She got kicked out of the AAA for... punkish behaviour. Stealing shit and being a menace. That's what I heard, at least. Jonah told me she kept wrecking his expeditions, too."
- She genuinely doesn't know that Fanghe left or that her father was a Chimera. If the Players tell her, she'll believe them because it makes sense with the tension between Fanghe and Chaarani.
- "So anyway, I let her steal my AAA card."
 - She was bored; she thought it'll be funny if Fanghe actually stole something.
 - She knows it can incriminate her, but she really doesn't care. She doesn't think Fanghe will do something *that* bad, anyway.
- If asked if she thinks Fanghe did it: "I don't know. Maybe. That girl has all the reasons to!"

Chaarani

- For the first time, Sloane goes silent. She looks like she sobered a little.
- "What about her?"
- She only speaks very factually and dryly of Chaarani: she's been the director of the AAA for close to a year, she's Sloane's boss, and she's Fanghe's mother.
- She gives no real personal opinion of Chaarani, even with skill checks. She has nothing to say about her.
- If asked about how the AAA treats her, she goes back to her drunk self.
 - She doesn't mind it: she doesn't have to give museum talks to people or to entertain them or anything like that. She can be left alone to do paperwork passed to her, which is what she wants.
 - INSIGHT DC 15: This is a front. She does mind it partially: she wants to do real work that inspires her instead of mindless paperwork day in, day out. She misses

her field work. She really, really does.

Caroline

- "Why are you asking me about her? I don't know anything about her. Talk to her yourself."

Caroline Gladkov

Female, 'Common' (Cyborg), 38 y/o

Personality and Characteristics

A quiet, meek, and nervous lady. She's very soft-spoken and overwhelmed with everything.

Though she's paranoid about keeping DEVIANT a secret, she still wants to leave her mark as an artist and political activist. She'll comment on the meaning behind the vandalism whenever she can and ask if the Players understand it as often as she can, without being ridiculous with it: "If you peel back the layer of Common society, you'll find the Cyborgs that were hidden by that same society... yet the Cyborgs were always there, even in the Old world. How fascinating..."

INSIGHT DC 15: Players realise that she's not very upset over her vandalised work: she seems more intrigued by it. She can always make more paintings, anyway.

- INSIGHT DC 20: She's anxious, but the Players have a feeling that it's not because of her ruined exhibition. They're not sure what else she's nervous about, though.
- If asked, she'll say that she's worried about what everyone will think of her work. This isn't a lie, but it's not the whole truth, either.

If the Players talk about Caroline's art techniques or inspirations, it'll eventually lead to her talking about the Hollow, as per 'The Paintings'. She'll go into more detail where she'd take solo trips to the Hollow just to draw, paint, or take pictures by herself. But that was in the past: she doesn't do that any more. She tried going to a ruined museum herself and got injured. She hasn't returned to the Hollow since.

Through talking about Caroline's art journey in the Hollow, DIPLOMACY DC 11 is enough for her to reveal that her injury in the Hollow legally makes her a Cyborg. She may not look like one, but her heart is fully mechanical. Getting this personal information through other means raises the DC. Intimidation will make the DC the highest, as she becomes scared for herself.

Suspect Profile

Alibi(s):

- She's an artist at her first solo exhibition. Why would she ruin her own work on such an important day?

Motive(s):

- She has a large pair of **scissors** in her bag that can cut a canvas.
- Secret revealed: She's a Cyborg; the vandalism is Pro-Cyborg.

Secret(s):

- She's a Cyborg! (See 'The Truth' above)

What's in her bag:

- Medical equipment, including a doctor's note and a large pair of **scissors**. She claims it's for her pacemaker (see 'The Truth' above).
 - INSIGHT DC 15: This isn't the whole truth.
- Other normal, unnotable things

Caroline's knowledge and opinions on...

The AAA suspects: She doesn't know enough to say anything about them, besides repeating the exhibition submission process with Chaarani.

The Aftermath

Regardless of who the Players unanimously accuse as the culprit, Caroline will be overcome with guilt and fear, making her reveal everything. By the end of it, she finds her courage and declares that this is her statement she wants to make to the world: just because someone looks different, or has fur, or has metal parts, or anything, it doesn't make them any less human.

Sloane, drunk, claps loudly and cheers. Chaarani also claps, playing it off as if this was always part of the exhibition. This is to protect AAA's reputation of their backroom being sabotaged.

She wraps up the case and lets the guests carry on. If the Players got the right culprit, Chaarani rewards them (gacha). If they didn't, she'll express quiet disappointment behind a smile and leaves. Instead, Sloane invites the Players to her office to take whatever's lying around (gacha), as a thank-you for entertaining her.

When the Dust Settles...

Once the closing ORP ends, some behind-the-scenes things happen the next day.

- If the Players tell Jonah they know he's a Chimera from Fanghe, he'll confront her about it.
- Chaarani privately reprimands a sober Sloane for letting Fanghe sneak past her. Sloane defends Fanghe: if she stole those Cyborg paintings, at least they won't be shelved away forever where no one will see them.
- Chaarani scolds Fanghe for trying to break into the AAA. To protect AAA's image, she's spinning a story that Fanghe was already an AAA member when she did that. She blackmails Fanghe into re-joining the AAA by threatening to turn her in to the cops, as there is evidence of her breaking into private property. Even if Fanghe doesn't get arrested for long, it'll remain on her record. Fanghe gives in. She's very unhappy.